Kamran's men ambushed the prince. The first Hindal managed to wrestle aside, but the second cut him dead with a spear and stole his bag of thumb rings as a prize.

It was a while before anyone realized the prince was dead.

Kamran's raid was repelled, and he retreated with his men, taking stock of their plunder. The soldier who brought him the thumb rings was an Afghan mercenary, not a Chagatai who might have known the prince, and might even have spared him. Kamran, however, recognized the little bag of rings immediately. He took off his turban and threw it to the ground in grief, crying 'Hindal had been martyred'.[52]

Humayun, meanwhile, was calling out for Hindal in the dark, over the sound of his men celebrating victory. He got no reply; it would be a while before he understood why.

The prince who had once vowed to protect his mothers and sisters with his last breath did, in fact, die with chivalry, defending someone in danger – not a woman from his harem but a servant from his household. He was buried at his father Babur's feet in a Kabul garden, but the anguish of his passing lived on. Decades later, his sister Gulbadan was still
struck with grief when she wrote the lines that tell of his demise: 'Would that merciless sword had touched my heart and eyes . . .!'

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And what, meanwhile, of Akbar? Only a few days previously, the nine-year-old prince had forgotten his turban when riding out to greet his father. Seeing his nephew in breach of protocol, Hindal had taken his own turban off and put it on Akbar's head.[53] Did they share the kind of affectionate, joking relationship that often exists between young uncles and their nephews and nieces? Perhaps. Does Akbar's bare-headed appearance reveal a loose, careless swagger, even an impatience with conventions? It's not unlikely.

Akbar had grown, and his personality was showing. Six-odd months after he was dangled over the battlements of Kabul, when he was exactly four years, four months and four days old – the auspicious age for beginning a child's education – he was given his first tutor: Mullazada Mulla Isamuddin Ibrahim. Much ceremony was attached to the event; Humayun had divined